FARM WASTE DEBATE

A recent study[37], undertaken by the *Central Institute of Post-Harvest Engineering and Technology (CIPHET)*, a government-run institute, has estimated the value of farm waste in India at Rs 44,000 crore (at the prices of 2009), that is around 7% of the total produce which is much lower than the oft-stated 40% level. Although cereals, such as wheat and rice, pulses and oil seeds accounted for around two-thirds of the wastage, the loss in case of fruits and vegetables was the highest at up to 18% of the total produce.

Attending the causes of storage and processing facilities, something the GoI is emphasising, this level could come down significantly and can serve great purpose in helping the economy to fight the repeated price shocks of the past two years in case of fruits, vegetables and foodgrains to a great extent.

The losses take place in almost all stages of farming but ***the study*** looked at harvesting, collection, grading, cleaning, packaging, transportation and storage. If cultivation was also included the loss would figure would be much higher. The GoI has said that availability of better technology and their adoption has brought about a reduction in losses.

IRRIGATION

The Planning Commission[38] classifies irrigation projects/schemes in India on the following lines :

1. *Major Irrigation Schemes*—Those with cultivable command areas (CCA) more than 10,000 hectares.
2. *Medium Irrigation Schemes*—Those with cultivable command areas (CCA) between 2,000 and 10,000 hectares.
3. *Minor Irrigation Schemes*—Those with cultivable command area (CCA) upto 2,000 hectares. Expansion of irrigation facilities, along with consolidation of the existing systems, has been the main part of the strategy for increasing production of foodgrains.